



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: August 28, 2026	Entry: 1
Description	Initial journal entry documenting a ransomware incident reported at a small U.S. primary-care clinic. Employees lost access to computers and patient records on Tuesday morning, and a ransom note demanding payment for a decryption key was displayed across affected machines. This entry captures the facts as first reported, ahead of formal detection, containment, and recovery steps.
Tool(s) used	None specified in the initial incident report. Next steps would include reviewing email gateway/spam-filter logs to trace the phishing message, EDR or antivirus alerts on affected endpoints to identify the ransomware, and SIEM logs to scope which systems were touched.
The 5 W's	● Who: An organized group of unethical hackers known for targeting the healthcare and transportation industries. They gained initial access by sending targeted phishing emails to clinic employees. ● What: A phishing email containing a malicious attachment installed malware on an employee's computer once downloaded. The attackers then deployed ransomware that encrypted the clinic's critical files,

	including patient records, and displayed a ransom note demanding payment for the decryption key. ● When: The incident was discovered on a Tuesday morning at approximately 9:00 a.m., when employees first reported being locked out of their systems. ● Where: The incident occurred on the internal computer network of a small U.S. health care clinic that provides primary-care services, affecting employee workstations and access to patient data. ● Why: An employee downloaded a malicious attachment from a phishing email, giving the attackers a foothold to deploy ransomware. Their motive was financial — extorting payment from the clinic in exchange for restoring access to its encrypted files.
Additional notes	Open questions to chase down as the investigation continues: how many employees received or opened the phishing email, whether any patient data was exfiltrated before encryption (double extortion) or only encrypted in place, and whether clean, isolated backups exist so recovery doesn't depend on paying the ransom. Given this is a health care organization, this incident likely qualifies as a HIPAA breach requiring notification to HHS Office for Civil Rights, and law enforcement (e.g., the FBI) should be notified given the ransomware group's known targeting pattern.

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Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

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Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes: Record additional notes.
